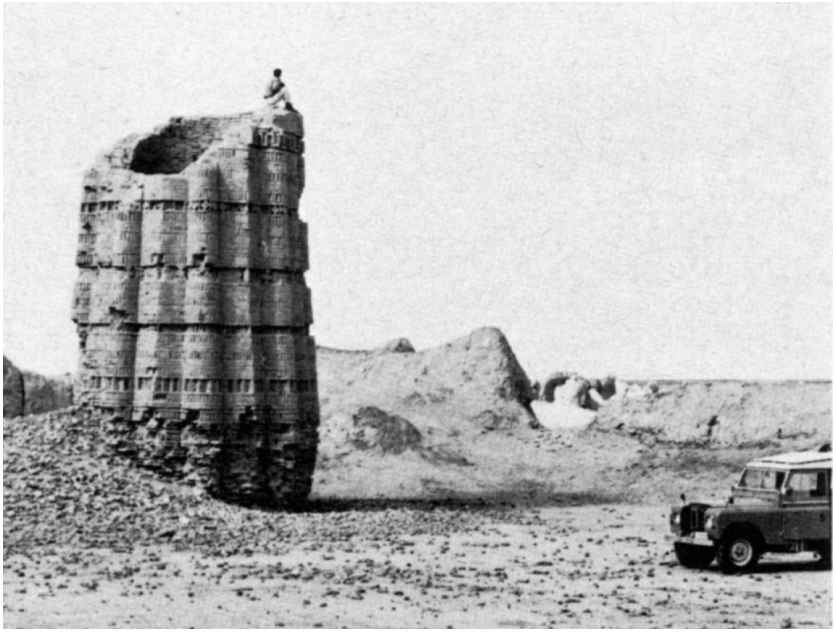


Figure 2.27 *Remains of baked-brick tower, Khwaja Siyah Push, Sistan. From Fischer et al. 1974: ill. 253.*

"cosmopolitan" patronage as well as non-elite, "vernacular" iterations: Rather than one being of lesser or greater artistic merit, *all* instantiations of an identifiable architectural culture serve as equally valuable and informative historical expressions. For now, we must be satisfied with the proviso that more thorough access to Da Qadi and its surroundings will eventually provide less equivocal answers to the questions still lingering around the date and architectural–cultural belonging of its *minar*.

Without epigraphical and other types of evidence, at present it is possible to put forth only hypotheses regarding the timeline and impetuses for constructing the Da Qadi *minar*. But based on Juzjani's mention of such a structure and its location, it is not unreasonable to propose that the tower was the result of Shansabani patronage at the beginning of the twelfth century. In turn, we must trace the consequential ramifications of such a proposal. The tower itself was not only an "Islamic" gesture, it was pronouncedly an act of architectural patronage. It could thereby signal not only the Shansabanis' public declaration of an Islamicate identity, but also the beginnings of an awareness of and transition toward the Persianate cultures of power prevalent among the elites of this geo-cultural expanse. As discussed in Chapter 1, these cultures were iterated distinctly within each polity, yet they can be conceived as founded upon three broad spheres of activity, *viz.* Islamic confessionalism, patronage, and mobility. Quite conceivably, in the first quarter of the twelfth century the Shansabanis